

POU11011 — Discussion points and tutorials

The 10% component · Michaelmas Term 2026

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New document — Claude’s proposal. Your habit is “further guidelines will be posted on Blackboard”; this is that, written down early. The rules are yours, from the syllabus. The surrounding advice — what makes a good point, what doesn’t — is Claude’s, built from last year’s Intro mechanics and your Comparative A response-paper conventions. Cut it to a paragraph if you’d rather.

The short version

Weight	10% of the module mark
What you submit	Three numbered discussion points, 200–400 words
How many times	Four — one before each tutorial
When	The evening before the tutorial, by 20:00
Where	The Discussion Points folder on Blackboard
Marked	Pass/fail. Two points per tutorial attended with an accepted submission, to a maximum of eight
The catch	You must submit <i>and</i> attend. Either one alone earns nothing

What to write

Three numbered points, 200–400 words in total.

You are not being asked for a polished analysis — you are being asked to raise something worth twenty minutes of argument.

Things that work:

- What the argument requires to be true.
- Where it fits the cases badly — name the case.
- Something in the news the reading explains, or fails to.
- Whether you believe it, and the alternative explanation.
- Two readings that disagree, and why.

Things that do not work: summarising the reading; three variations on “this was interesting”; a point that could have been written without opening the text.

Rough prose is fine.

The mechanics

Which tutorials. All four. Submit three numbered discussion points before each one.

Deadline: 20:00 the evening before your tutorial meets. Late points are not accepted — not at 21:00, not the next morning, and never after the tutorial has met.

Marking. Pass/fail. Two points for each tutorial attended with an accepted submission, to a maximum of eight. Your TA can reject a submission that is too short or makes no genuine attempt at the reading.

The 80 cap. Departmental policy caps this component at 80. Six points earns a mark of 80, with reductions proportional to that.

The Assignment Submission Form. Required as the first page of every discussion-points submission, same as the blog post and the final essay (Noah, 2026-09-16: the form is now required department-wide on every piece of written work). A submission without one is not accepted.

Attendance

Attendance is compulsory and is half of this component: submitting without attending, or attending without submitting, earns nothing for that tutorial.

Excused absence (certified medical reasons only) requires your **College Tutor** to contact your TA and me. The credit procedure for an excused tutorial is in the [module outline](#).

Generative AI

Short version: don't.

Category	This component
Brainstorming	Not permitted. The point is that <i>you</i> had a reaction to the reading.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted, for one thing only: clarifying a term or passage you could not follow after genuinely trying — not for summarising the reading.
Writing assistance	Not permitted. These are short and ungraded on style; spellcheck is fine.
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted.

A rough, obviously human page is worth more here than a smooth one.

Dates

Tutorial	Date	Discussion points due
1	[TBD]	[TBD], 20:00
2	[TBD]	[TBD], 20:00
3	[TBD]	[TBD], 20:00
4	[TBD]	[TBD], 20:00

Tutorial group allocation appears in your timetable. Dates and rooms are confirmed on Blackboard.